

8 NHS Telephone Triage English Lines That Nurses Use

Eight questions for a call where you cannot see the person you are assessing. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact questions a senior triage nurse asks, in the order she asks them.

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

What made you pick up the phone today?

/wɒt meɪd juː pɪk ʌp ðə fəʊn tə'deɪ/

FINDING THE REAL REASON FOR THE CALL

INSTEAD OF How can I help you?

Why it works. How can I help gets a polite answer. This question asks what changed. People ring when something frightens them. That is the thing you need first.

What made you pick up the phone today? Take your time.

Ano po ang dahilan kaya kayo tumawag ngayon?

2/8

Describe it to me as if I am standing next to you.

/dɪ'skraɪb ɪt tuː miː æz ɪf aɪ æm 'stændɪŋ nekst tuː juː/

ASKING FOR WHAT THEY CAN SEE, NOT FOR A LABEL

INSTEAD OF So is it a bad pain?

Why it works. A yes or no question gives you one word. This one gives you a picture. Callers repeat medical words they found on the internet. Their own words are worth much more.

Describe it to me as if I am standing next to you. What would I see?

Ilarawan ninyo po ito sa akin na parang katabi ninyo ako.

3/8

When were you last completely yourself?

/wɛn wɜː juː lɑːst kəm'pliːtli jɔː'self/

FINDING WHEN IT STARTED

INSTEAD OF How long has this been going on?

Why it works. How long gets a guess. This question asks for a moment. People remember moments. They work out lengths of time, and the answer is often far out.

When were you last completely yourself? Take me from there.

Kailan po kayo huling naging maayos talaga?

4/8

You would not have called if it was nothing.

/ju: wʊd nɒt hæv kɔ:ld ɪf ɪt wəz 'nʌθɪŋ/

ANSWERING THE CALLER WHO PLAYS IT DOWN

INSTEAD OF Do not worry, it is probably fine.

Why it works. Do not worry ends the conversation. This sentence gives the caller permission. Most people ring late because they feel they are making a fuss. Say it, and they tell you the rest.

You would not have called if it was nothing. Tell me what worried you.

Hindi po sana kayo tumawag kung wala talagang problema.

5/8

Is there anyone with you who has seen you today?

/ɪz ðeər 'ɛniwʌn wɪð ju: hu: hæz si:n ju: tə'deɪ/

FINDING A SECOND PAIR OF EYES

INSTEAD OF How have you been in yourself today?

Why it works. A person who is unwell is the worst witness to it. Someone who saw them yesterday can say what has changed. You have no eyes on this call. Somebody in that room does.

Is there anyone with you who has seen you today? Could I have a word with them?

May kasama po ba kayo diyan na nakakita sa inyo ngayong araw?

6/8

I need to ask about some things that may sound unrelated.

/aɪ niːd tuː ɑːsk əˈbaʊt sʌm θɪŋz ðæt meɪ saʊnd ʌnɪˈleɪtɪd/

ASKING THE HARD QUESTIONS WITHOUT FRIGHTENING ANYBODY

INSTEAD OF Have you got any other symptoms?

Why it works. Any other symptoms asks the caller to decide what matters. They cannot. This sentence says the odd questions are normal. Then nobody panics when you ask one.

I need to ask about some things that may sound unrelated. It is routine.

Kailangan ko pong magtanong ng ilang bagay na parang walang kinalaman.

7/8

What is worrying you most about this?

/wɒt ɪz ˈwʌrɪŋ juː məʊst əˈbaʊt ðɪs/

ASKING FOR THE CALLER'S OWN JUDGEMENT

INSTEAD OF Anything else you want to tell me?

Why it works. You already asked what made them ring. Ask what frightens them again at the end, after they have said it all out loud. The first answer is why they dialled. The second one is what they have been carrying since Thursday, and it is rarely the same answer.

What is worrying you most about this, in your own words?

Ano po ang pinaka-ikinababahala ninyo dito?

8/8

Two things now. One to do, and one to watch for.

/tu: θɪŋz naʊ wʌn tu: du: ænd wʌn tu: wɒtʃ fɔ:/

GIVING A PLAN THE CALLER CAN ACTUALLY HOLD

INSTEAD OF Just ring us again if you are still not happy.

Why it works. A long plan is forgotten by the front door. Two is the number a frightened person can carry. Not because the plan is simple, but because their memory is already full. Say three and you lose all three.

Two things now. One to do, and one to watch for. Then I will let you go.

Dalawang bagay po ngayon. Isang gagawin, isang babantayan.

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Reason · Picture · Worst · Plan

Four steps. If you remember nothing else on the phones tonight, remember that order. A caller who is asked why they rang, then what they can see, then the difficult questions, tells you far more. A caller asked to describe a symptom tells you very little.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. The caller starts listing symptoms. You still do not know why tonight.

What made you pick up the phone today?

How can I help gets a polite answer. This question asks what changed. People ring when something frightens them. That is the thing you need first.

2. The caller keeps naming a condition he read about online.

Describe it to me as if I am standing next to you.

A yes or no question gives you one word. This one gives you a picture. Callers repeat medical words they found on the internet. Their own words are worth much more.

3. The caller says it has been going on for a while.

When were you last completely yourself?

How long gets a guess. This question asks for a moment. People remember moments. They work out lengths of time, and the answer is often far out.

4. The caller says it is probably nothing and starts to end the call.

You would not have called if it was nothing.

Do not worry ends the conversation. This sentence gives the caller permission. Most people ring late because they feel they are making a fuss. Say it, and they tell you the rest.

5. Everything you have is the caller's own account of himself.

Is there anyone with you who has seen you today?

A person who is unwell is the worst witness to it. Someone who saw them yesterday can say what has changed. You have no eyes on this call. Somebody in that room does.

6. You have to ask the questions nobody volunteers.

I need to ask about some things that may sound unrelated.

Any other symptoms asks the caller to decide what matters. They cannot. This sentence says the odd questions are normal. Then nobody panics when you ask one.

7. You have the facts. You still do not have the caller's own fear.

What is worrying you most about this?

You already asked what made them ring. Ask what frightens them again at the end, after they have said it all out loud. The first answer is why they dialled. The second one is what they have been carrying since Thursday, and it is rarely the same answer.

8. The call is ending. Make sure the plan leaves the phone with him.

Two things now. One to do, and one to watch for.

A long plan is forgotten by the front door. Two is the number a frightened person can carry. Not because the plan is simple, but because their memory is already full. Say three and you lose all three.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day **Day 3**

Three days ago you learned the four steps: reason, picture, worst, plan. New situation. The caller is not the person who is unwell — it is her daughter, ringing from another city, and she has not seen her mother today. Which of the four steps gets harder, and which question would you change?

7/day

Day 7

One week in. This is the one people get wrong. The caller wants you to tell him it is fine, and he says so. Two questions from this lesson still work here, and one of them is the only thing that will get you an honest answer. Can you remember which?

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